

everyone *should* go to college. In fact, colleges and universities tend to create excellent employees, but if you want to make a great living, be your own boss, provide for your family, and have enough to retire well—and if you're at all entrepreneurial—consider the trades.

Plumbers, electricians, repair specialists, mechanics, chefs—these are jobs that are always in demand, are fairly mobile, and, most important, pay well. So think outside the cubicle. Think beyond the “office box.” Skilled trades don't require years and years of expensive schooling, and if you do graduate with debt, it'll likely be manageable. My favorite part of choosing a trade: Many of the best tradespeople go into business for themselves, in turn employing the young graduates as apprentices in their companies.

I like entrepreneurs, and I like trades as a vocation a lot, because you're still pursuing a higher education, which I insist on, but this path casts an eye toward the bigger picture. So if you're wishy-washy about your future and going to college only because your friends are, it could be the single biggest mistake you make, especially if you're footing the bill through a six-figure loan. And if you're resisting the vocational path because of some misguided stigma against trades, get over it. I've never met a poor, unhappy plumber who works for him- or herself. Let's face it: If you're realistic, you might not even be college material. I certainly wasn't. I have an irrepressible entrepreneurial streak that, luckily, was nurtured by my parents and my mentors. I got through college, sure, but I now know it wasn't the only option.

According to the U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, employees made an average hourly wage of \$23.73. Compare that to \$24.92, the national average for plumbers, or \$25.44, the average hourly wage for an electrician. These tradespeople earn an average hourly wage 5 to 7 percent higher than other professions. Many of them also work for themselves, set their own hours, and hire and fire their teams. And they make a lot more money when they work for themselves or work in certain areas. Case in point: There are only a few big contracting companies in the lake-house community where I own a summer home. In many instances, the contractors' homes are much bigger than those